A WorkSmart-AI Guide for Higher Education

From Chatbot to Workflow

One task. Four levels.

What your staff could be doing.

This guide takes one task every member of staff does every week and shows how it evolves from a basic chatbot prompt to an automated workflow that runs without them.

Level 1
Conversational

Level 2
Structured

Level 3
Configured

Level 4
Agentic

Most AI training stops at Level 1.

The majority of higher education staff who use AI at all are at Level 1: opening a chatbot, typing a question, reading the answer. Useful - also approximately 20% of what is possible.

Off-the-shelf workshops tend to reinforce this. A session on "how to write a better prompt" leaves staff with better one-off results but no system, no progression, and no connection to the tools they use every day. Six months later, most staff have drifted back to old habits.

The organisations seeing real productivity gains are moving staff through a structured progression - from ad hoc chatbot use, to repeatable structured prompting, to configured tools, to automated workflows. Each step is accessible. Each step builds directly on the last.

This guide shows what that progression looks like using one task that every member of staff in higher education recognises.

> ***"Moving from Level 1 to Level 2 alone can save 2-3 hours per staff member per week across common tasks. Most HE institutions are leaving that time on the table."***

The WorkSmart-AI Use Hierarchy

Six levels of AI use, each building on the last. Most HE staff currently sit at Level 1.

1 **Conversational AI**
Single-turn chatbot use. Paste, read, review manually.
All staff

2 **Structured Prompting**
R-C-T frameworks. AI embedded in M365 tools such as Copilot in Teams.
All staff

3 **Custom Configuration**
Custom GPTs, Copilot agents, persistent instructions. Configured once.
All staff

4 **Agentic Workflows**
Multi-step automated tasks via Power Automate. Minimal human input.
All staff (adv.)

5 **Specialist AI Tools**
Purpose-built AI for specific roles - research, legal, finance.
Role-specific

6 **Integration & Orch.**
API connections and multi-agent pipelines. IT and digital leads.
IT / Digital

This guide follows one task through Levels 1-4. Levels 5-6 are referenced as the horizon, being available as part of our client packages.

1 Conversational AI

Where most HE staff are right now.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- A staff member opens ChatGPT, Copilot chat, or a similar chatbot.
- They copy-paste rough notes and add a one-line request.
- They read the output, edit manually, and send it on.
- Next time, the same ad hoc process starts again from scratch.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

```
Here are my rough notes from today's meeting.
Please tidy them up and pull out the key
action points.
Format as:
  (1) Short summary
  (2) Decisions made
  (3) Actions - owner and deadline for each

[paste your notes here]
```

15-20 mins
estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY
Variable. Better than nothing, but inconsistent across staff and occasions.

Tools: ChatGPT (free), Microsoft Copilot chat (free tier), Google Gemini

2 Structured Prompting

Same task. A repeatable system.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- Staff apply the R-C-T framework - Role, Context, Task - every time.
- They use Copilot inside Teams or Word, where the meeting happened.
- They maintain a saved prompt template for recurring meeting types.
- Output is consistent, shareable, and requires only light review.

EXAMPLE PROMPT

```
Role: You are an experienced PA
at a UK university.
Context: I have just finished a
45-minute project steering
meeting. Attendees: HoD, Project
Manager, Finance Lead, IT Lead.
Task: Produce a meeting summary
with:
  (1) Decisions made
  (2) Action items - owner role
and deadline for each
  (3) Items to carry forward
Use formal, concise language
suitable for circulation.

[paste your notes here]
```

25-35 mins
estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

Consistent and shareable. Can be circulated after light review rather than a full redraft.

Tools: Microsoft Copilot in Teams or Word (M365 licence), ChatGPT with saved prompt library

3 Custom Configuration

Configured once. Works every time.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- A Custom GPT or Copilot agent is built once with the institutional template loaded.
- It knows your headings, terminology, and governance language.
- Staff paste notes in - no configuration needed each time.
- Different agents can cover different meeting types.

SYSTEM CONFIGURATION (set once, shared with all staff)

Institutional meeting note template loaded as system instructions

Required headings:
Attendees | Summary | Decisions | Actions | Carry Forward

Preferred terminology and governance or compliance language pre-loaded

Staff input: paste notes only - no prompting skills required

Separate agents available for:
Steering | Welfare checks | Committee papers

35-45 mins
estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY

Near-zero formatting work. Output matches your institutional template automatically. One build serves the whole team.

Tools: ChatGPT Plus (Custom GPTs), Microsoft Copilot Studio (M365 licence)

4 Agentic Workflows

The task runs itself.

THE TASK: Meeting notes → clean action summary for circulation.

What this looks like

- Teams transcribes the meeting automatically as it happens.
- Power Automate detects the completed transcript and triggers the workflow.
- The structured summary is saved to SharePoint automatically.
- Action owners receive email notifications. Zero post-meeting admin.

AUTOMATED FLOW (no manual steps required)

Teams records and transcribes the meeting in real time

↓

Power Automate detects new transcript and triggers the workflow

↓

Copilot generates structured summary using institutional template

↓

Summary saved to SharePoint + action owners emailed automatically

50-60 mins
estimated time saved

OUTPUT QUALITY
The task removes itself from the to-do list. Available today in M365. This is not a future capability.

Tools: Microsoft Teams transcription, Power Automate, Copilot (M365 Copilot licence required)

Now imagine this applied to...

Every task follows the same four-level arc - from chatbot prompt to automated workflow. Where do your staff currently sit on each one?

Student Enquiry Responses

Registry staff handling high-volume routine queries consistently and at speed.

Assessment Feedback Drafts

Academic staff generating structured, criteria-referenced feedback at scale.

Onboarding New Staff

HR producing personalised induction packs tailored to each new starter's role.

Research Grant Applications

Researchers drafting background sections and methodology outlines from notes.

Processing Committee Papers

Governance teams summarising board packs with decisions and actions extracted.

Drafting Job Adverts

HR creating role-specific job descriptions from bullet-point briefs.

Module Handbook Updates

Programme leaders refreshing course docs and ILOs each academic year.

Student Welfare Comms

Personal tutors generating welfare outreach messages for at-risk students.

These are 8 of the 220+ use cases in the WorkSmart-AI HE Use Case Bank. Every one follows the same progression.

Take your staff from Level 1 to Level 4.

WorkSmart-AI is a UK-based AI training and consultancy business built specifically for higher education. We design and deliver structured AI literacy programmes that take staff through the full hierarchy - not just the first step.

Workshop Programme

W1-W12 covering all staff roles and hierarchy levels. From foundations through to agentic workflows.

All staff

HE Use Case Bank

290+ use cases mapped to 14 staff roles. Green/Amber/Red risk ratings. Ready-to-use prompt starters.

Included in all programmes

Leadership Clarity

Strategic 1:1 advisory for senior leaders. Designed for VCs, PVCs, and Directors.

Senior leadership

Start with a free 45-minute conversation.

Book a call: worksmart-ai.co.uk

Email us: hello@worksmart-ai.co.uk

LinkedIn: linkedin.com/company/worksmart-ai

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